

Iberian lynx

Lynx pardinus

The Iberian lynx is the most endangered cat on Earth. Once found throughout Spain and Portugal, as well as in southern France, fewer than 250 breeding adults are left in the wild, mostly confined to two tiny areas of southern Spain. This is largely due to human impact, but the lynx's highly specialized diet and habitat requirements have also contributed to its decline.

Reliant upon rabbits

This muscular, spotted wild cat has evolved to feed mainly on one animal—the European rabbit. In summer, rabbits make up as much as 93 percent of the lynx's diet, which means that if rabbit populations fall due to hunting or diseases, so do lynx numbers. If it has no other choice, the Iberian lynx will hunt rodents, hares, ducks, or even small deer, but it has become so specialized in its tastes that, without rabbits, its numbers inevitably decline.

Added to this is the increasing destruction of the lynx's habitat due to the rise in human population. The Iberian lynx prefers large areas of dense scrubland, such as heather interspersed with open pasture. Since lynxes are highly territorial and solitary as adults, maturing juveniles that leave their birth zones in search of their own territories face a high risk of being hit by traffic,

which in recent decades has increased dramatically in southern Spain. Even when they make it to adulthood, female lynxes will breed only after they establish their own territories.

Lynxes mate mainly during January and February, and before giving birth, a pregnant female will establish a den in a hollow tree, cave, or other sheltered spot, such as underneath dense bushes. Up to four cubs are born about two months later, although rarely more than two survive to weaning stage. Caring for her offspring puts an extra strain on the mother in many ways; a female lynx with cubs to feed needs to catch at least three rabbits a day, as opposed to the one she requires for herself. In addition, the female changes den sites frequently in order to keep the cubs safe. Like many species of wild cat, Iberian lynxes are primarily nocturnal, and spend the day resting away from the heat of the sun.

Future imperfect

Captive breeding programs and stricter hunting and development restrictions have led to a slight increase in Iberian lynx numbers, but conservationists are uncertain whether it will survive in the wild.

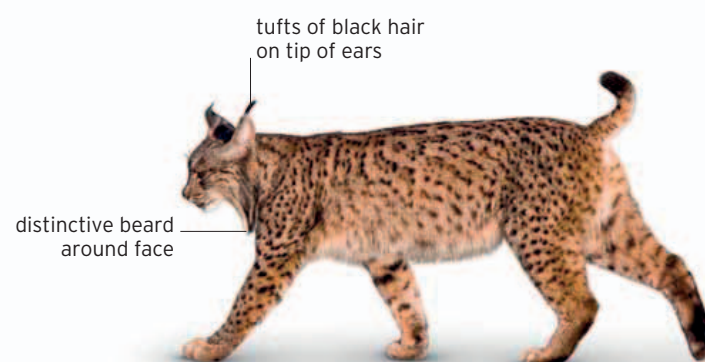
▷ KILLING BITE

Unlike larger cats, Iberian lynxes kill with a single bite, puncturing the rabbit's neck and severing its spinal cord.



▷ MOTHER AND CUB

Lynx cubs are weaned at 10 weeks and become independent at seven or eight months old, although they may remain with their mother for longer.



↔ 34–43 in (85–110 cm)

⚖ 22–29 lb (10–13 kg)

⊗ Critically endangered

🐰 Rabbits



SW. Europe

▷ BEARDED CAT

Tufts of long, mainly black fur around the face give adult lynxes a bearded appearance, which makes their narrow jawline seem broader.

